

Browser Session Management

Run multiple isolated browser sessions concurrently with state persistence.

Named Browser Sessions

Use -s flag to isolate browser contexts:

Browser 1: Authentication flow

```
playwright-cli -s=auth open https://app.example.com/login
```

Browser 2: Public browsing (separate cookies, storage)

```
playwright-cli -s=public open https://example.com
```

Commands are isolated by browser session

```
playwright-cli -s=auth fill el "user@example.com"
```

```
playwright-cli -s=public snapshot
```

Browser Session Isolation Properties

Each browser session has independent: - Cookies - LocalStorage / SessionStorage - IndexedDB - Cache - Browsing history - Open tabs

Browser Session Commands

List all browser sessions

```
playwright-cli list
```

Stop a browser session (close the browser)

```
playwright-cli close
```

stop the default browser

```
playwright-cli -s=mysession close
```

stop a named browser

Stop all browser sessions

```
playwright-cli close-all
```

Forcefully kill all daemon processes (for stale/zombie processes)

```
playwright-cli kill-all
```

Delete browser session user data (profile directory)

```
playwright-cli delete-data
```

delete default browser data

```
playwright-cli -s=mysession delete-data
```

delete named browser data

Environment Variable

Set a default browser session name via environment variable:

```
export PLAYWRIGHT_CLI_SESSION="mysession"
playwright-cli open example.com # Uses "mysession" automatically
```

Common Patterns

Concurrent Scraping

```
#!/bin/bash
# Scrape multiple sites concurrently

# Start all browsers
playwright-cli -s=site1 open https://site1.com &
playwright-cli -s=site2 open https://site2.com &
playwright-cli -s=site3 open https://site3.com &
wait

# Take snapshots from each
playwright-cli -s=site1 snapshot
playwright-cli -s=site2 snapshot
playwright-cli -s=site3 snapshot

# Cleanup
playwright-cli close-all
```

A/B Testing Sessions

```
# Test different user experiences
playwright-cli -s=variant-a open "https://app.com?variant=a"
playwright-cli -s=variant-b open "https://app.com?variant=b"

# Compare
playwright-cli -s=variant-a screenshot
playwright-cli -s=variant-b screenshot
```

Persistent Profile

By default, browser profile is kept in memory only. Use `--persistent` flag on open to persist the browser profile to disk:

```
# Use persistent profile (auto-generated location)
playwright-cli open https://example.com --persistent
```

```
# Use persistent profile with custom directory  
playwright-cli open https://example.com --profile=/path/to/profile
```

Attaching to a Running Browser

Use attach to connect to a browser that is already running, instead of launching a new one.

Attach by channel name

Connect to a running Chrome or Edge instance by its channel name. The browser must have remote debugging enabled — navigate to `chrome://inspect/#remote-debugging` in the target browser and check “Allow remote debugging for this browser instance”.

```
# Attach to Chrome  
playwright-cli attach --cdp=chrome
```

```
# Attach to Chrome Canary  
playwright-cli attach --cdp=chrome-canary
```

```
# Attach to Microsoft Edge  
playwright-cli attach --cdp=msedge
```

```
# Attach to Edge Dev  
playwright-cli attach --cdp=msedge-dev
```

Supported channels: chrome, chrome-beta, chrome-dev, chrome-canary, msedge, msedge-beta, msedge-dev, msedge-canary.

When `--session` is not provided, the session is named after the channel (e.g. `--cdp=msedge` creates a session called `msedge`), so parallel attaches to Chrome and Edge don’t collide on default. Pass `--session=<name>` to override.

Attach via CDP endpoint

Connect to a browser that exposes a Chrome DevTools Protocol endpoint:

```
playwright-cli attach --cdp=http://localhost:9222
```

Attach via browser extension

Connect to a browser with the Playwright extension installed:

```
playwright-cli attach --extension
```

Detach

Tear down an attached session without affecting the external browser:

```
# Detach the default attached session  
playwright-cli detach
```

```
# Detach a specific attached session  
playwright-cli -s=msedge detach
```

detach only works on sessions created via attach. For sessions created via open, use close.

Default Browser Session

When -s is omitted, commands use the default browser session:

```
# These use the same default browser session  
playwright-cli open https://example.com  
playwright-cli snapshot  
playwright-cli close # Stops default browser
```

Browser Session Configuration

Configure a browser session with specific settings when opening:

```
# Open with config file  
playwright-cli open https://example.com --config=.playwright/my-cli.json  
  
# Open with specific browser  
playwright-cli open https://example.com --browser=firefox  
  
# Open in headed mode  
playwright-cli open https://example.com --headed  
  
# Open with persistent profile  
playwright-cli open https://example.com --persistent
```

Best Practices

1. Name Browser Sessions Semantically

```
# GOOD: Clear purpose  
playwright-cli -s=github-auth open https://github.com  
playwright-cli -s=docs-scrape open https://docs.example.com
```

AVOID: Generic names

```
playwright-cli -s=s1 open https://github.com
```

2. Always Clean Up

Stop browsers when done

```
playwright-cli -s=auth close
```

```
playwright-cli -s=scrape close
```

Or stop all at once

```
playwright-cli close-all
```

If browsers become unresponsive or zombie processes remain

```
playwright-cli kill-all
```

3. Delete Stale Browser Data

Remove old browser data to free disk space

```
playwright-cli -s=oldsession delete-data
```